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INTRODUCTION: YOUTH WELL-BEING BY DESIGN

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Concern over young people's relationships with technology has been a regular focus of US public discourse and policy debates ever since young people led adoption of digital and social media in the late nineties. Concerns over digital marketing and online predators drove the passage of the Children's Online Privacy Protection Act in 1998 (boyd et al. 2011). The aughts saw the start of a steady stream of books suggesting that digital technology "stupefies young Americans" (Bauerlein 2009), makes us shallow thinkers (Carr 2010), and socially disconnects us (Turkle 2011). These concerns, and adult desire to limit and regulate young people's technology engagement, have been amplified by the growth of youth mental health issues since the 2010s, particularly in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic. A dominant narrative that technology use is driving a teen mental health crisis has taken hold. In June 2023, the US Surgeon General issued an Advisory on Social Media and Youth Mental Health (Office of the Surgeon General 2023). News outlets wasted no time in circulating headlines stoking adult fears: "Social media is driving teen mental health crisis, Surgeon General warns" and "Social media poses profound risk of harm." The actual advisory acknowledged a more nuanced, and measured, reality: "There is broad agreement among the scientific community that social media has the potential to both benefit and harm children and adolescents" (Office of the Surgeon General 2023, 5).

This dominant narrative that screen time causes teen mental health problems is grounded in persistent intergenerational dynamics and fears over new technology and youth culture. It persists even in the face of a countervailing scientific consensus (Odgers and Jensen 2020; Orben and Przybylski 2019) and lived experience in how technology is increasingly essential for learning, creation, and social connection. Media and technology researchers have documented these intergenerational conflicts that have accompanied every wave of youth “new” media adoption ever since Stanley Cohen (1972) coined the term “moral panic” to describe adult reaction to mods, rockers, and skinheads. New technology, media, and youth cultural forms threaten adult norms and taste and are routinely demonized and blamed for broader societal problems by the establishment.

Recognizing how cultural stigmas and fears over youth behavior color today’s discourses of teens and tech is essential to combating often well-meaning but misleading adult-centered narratives. These narratives are not only misleading but also materially harmful in diverting attention from well-established and critical drivers of well-being and mental health problems. In addition to the COVID-19 pandemic, the last decade saw significant growth in well-documented mental health stressors that disproportionately impact vulnerable and marginalized youth. These stressors span online and offline settings and include poverty, educational pressure, climate anxiety, hate, inequality, and political polarization. Specific features and uses of technology can amplify or mitigate these stressors. However, these dynamics can’t be understood through a simple narrative of technology addiction or harm, and can’t be resolved through blanket, adult-driven, age-based prohibitions or screen-time rules. Top-down solutions of this kind rob young people of agency and contribute to experiences of oppression and injustice, which, in turn, drive stress and erode intergenerational trust and support. Recognizing these dynamics is particularly critical as policymakers rush to implement social media and cell phone bans as a solution to the youth mental health crisis.

The dominant narratives about teens and technology also fail to recognize the diversity in experiences, dispositions, vulnerabilities, and ways of using technology. The advisory acknowledged a truth that is backed by research and common sense but was glossed over in the headlines: “Different children and adolescents are affected by social media in different ways

based on their individual strengths and vulnerabilities, and based on cultural, historical, and socio-economic factors” (Office of the Surgeon General 2023, 5). For some teens, online connections to affinity networks and identity-affirming content are indispensable sources of connection, comfort, care, and support. Other teens find their social media feeds full of content that wastes their time or erodes their confidence and self-worth and seek steps to limit their engagement. Most youth use varied technologies on an everyday basis, ranging from media creation and consumption apps, social media, and communication tools and games, and don’t see technology or even social media as singular or monolithic influences in their lives.

As longtime researchers of young people’s lives and uses of digital media, we are committed to uplifting more grounded, textured accounts of the relationship between media and well-being (Ito et al. 2009, 2018, 2020; Weinstein and James 2022). We are clear-eyed about both the benefits and challenges that digital and social media can present for youth’s physical health, mental health, social connectedness, learning, and civic development, among other outcomes. But we seek to elevate research that details where, how, when, and especially for whom those benefits and challenges manifest. Such research is essential both for public understanding and for technology design, intervention development, and policy.

This essay collection came together as part of a movement to bolster young people’s social and psychological well-being in a technology-rich world.¹ Essays provide readers with relevant, foundational insights from developmental science, sociocultural perspectives, well-being research, dignity theory, and more. The collection also describes relevant approaches, methods, and measures (e.g., youth codesign, critical race theory, critical digital literacies) for researching youth well-being as well as constructive design frameworks for technology design, online communities, and interventions. Insights across the collection make the case for four necessary frameshifts around tech and youth well-being:

- **From technological determinism to social shaping of technology:** Technology both shapes and is shaped by social and cultural contexts and is not an independent force causing a mental health crisis. Technology is intertwined with well-established influences on mental health and well-being, including individual vulnerabilities, poverty, social connection, and marginalization.

- **From individual screen time to socio-technical drivers of well-being:** Individual screen time is an inadequate (and problematic) measure for interrogating psychological well-being; well-being is situated and shaped by diverse facets of young people's lives that cut across online and offline settings.
- **From one-size-fits-all to tailored, asset-based solutions:** Young people's experiences with and orientation to technology are diverse and are situated within economic, social, and cultural inequalities. Solutions must be tailored to and tap the assets of marginalized and vulnerable youth to be effective and equitable.
- **From top-down to community-driven PD:** Designing for youth social and psychological well-being requires critical, humanizing, and participatory approaches that bring youth expertise to the table and accomplishes this in ways that acknowledge and remediate structural inequalities and power dynamics between adults and youth.

In this introduction, we describe how the essays in this volume make the case for these four crosscutting commitments to challenging inaccurate and damaging dominant narratives about young people, technology, and well-being.

FROM TECHNOLOGICAL DETERMINISM TO SOCIAL SHAPING OF TECHNOLOGY

Dominant narratives for understanding the relationship between young people and technology are rooted in technological determinism—a belief that technology is an independent force standing outside of culture and society. Headlines suggesting that social media or screen time “drives” or “causes” a teen mental health crisis position technology as an independent force with homogenous effects, failing to recognize that technology is both shaped by and shapes society and culture in unequal and heterogenous ways (Benjamin 2019; Pinch and Bijker 1984; Hine 2000). As health researchers record high levels of persistent sadness, hopelessness, and distress (particularly among those who identify as girls and/or LGBTQ+; CDC 2023), an urgent search for tractable causes and solutions has often led to technologically determinist finger-pointing at tech. Technological determinism in this vein is beguiling because it offers

a clear villain and positions adults as saviors and young people as incompetent and vulnerable victims in need of protection. It also absolves adult educational and public welfare institutions of responsibility and deflects attention from well-documented mental health risks such as poverty, racism, homophobia, transphobia, achievement pressure, sexism, and loss. The essays in this volume offer an alternative, unseating technology as an independent agent and recognizing our collective responsibility by examining social and cultural history and context and the role of diverse actors, including young people, in shaping technology.

Science and technology studies research describes the social shaping of new technology by analyzing how it grows from the history and soil of cultural assumptions, institutionalized practices, and structural inequity. The essays by Jenny Radesky and by Stephanie Reich and her colleagues critique the capitalist imperatives of Big Tech embedded in features such as notifications, flashy graphics, and recommendations that are designed to keep users engaged rather than prioritizing learning, healthy development, and well-being. They highlight the challenge of having these features foregrounded in default settings. Tiera Tanksley's essay excavates a different type of cultural default setting—how these platforms are descendants of a long lineage of white supremacist and anti-Black projects, assumptions, and structures. She describes how “race is a technology” and “anti-Blackness can be thought of as an algorithm,” challenging narratives about the neutrality and universalism of platforms and the code that guides them. Educational technology is not exempt from these fraught legacies. Cherise McBride and Earl Aguilera describe dehumanizing ideologies of control, hierarchy, and racial reductionism embedded in a training simulation for teachers.

Authors in this collection hold industry accountable, but they also surface the power and responsibility of varied stakeholders in fostering a healthy tech ecosystem. Recognizing the social and cultural shaping of technology creates openness to counternarratives and designs, policies, and practices fostered by diverse youth and their communities. The essays highlight the roles that young people do and can play in shaping technology: in everyday play and engagement with online spaces (Laliberte and Katz, Milosevic et al., Reich et al., and Salen Tekinbaş et al.), through design and codesign with adults (Tanksley and Weinstein et al.),